

PRODUCTION SUMMARY

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore

A Village Players production · Lausanne

A rehearsal is interrupted by six people no one invited.

THE PLAY

Pirandello's 1921 masterpiece begins in a theatre. A working company is rehearsing — when six characters from an unfinished play walk on stage and demand to be staged. What follows is one of the strangest, funniest, and most devastating arguments in twentieth-century theatre, between the actors who want to do their job and the strangers who insist their tragedy is the real one and must be told now.

THE STORY, ACT BY ACT

Act One — a working theatre company is mid-rehearsal of a play they do not like. They are interrupted by six characters, dressed in mourning, who arrive asking to be staged. The Father explains: they were once written, then abandoned by their author, and exist now as characters with no end to their drama. The Step-Daughter, in fury, pushes him to tell the story. The Manager, half intrigued and half horrified, agrees to try.

Act Two — the company attempts to perform the worst moment in the family's life: an encounter in the back room of a dressmaker's shop, between the Step-Daughter and her stepfather, that has gone wrong in ways neither of them can name. The actors try to copy what the Six describe. The Mother, who was not present at the original event but must witness it now, breaks. The gap between what truly happened and what the stage can hold becomes the subject of the play.

Act Three — in a garden, beside a low fountain, what cannot be staged finally arrives. The Boy stands silent by the basin. The Child wanders. The actors do not know whether to act it; the Manager has lost a whole day; and the curtain falls on a stage that has held more reality than theatre is built for.

OUR STAGING

Eight live performers; three acts; one defining visual per act — a circle of chairs in Act One, a two-level set (rehearsal stage above, watching floor below) in Act Two, a single short fountain basin alone on stage in Act Three. The Boy and the Child, the two youngest of the Six, are not played by performers; they are objects on the stage — a coat-and-chair, a wrapped bundle of white cloth — and appear only briefly in three short video projections on the rear wall.

A mostly black-box, minimalist staging. Lighting does much of the storytelling — every shift in tone marked by a change in the temperature of the room. The music score carries the scenes where text alone cannot reach, and pulls the audience through the long emotional arc from the opening comedy to whatever it is the last quarter of an hour becomes.

HOW IT PLAYS

The first quarter of an hour is committed comedy. The last quarter of an hour is not. The production runs in three acts with an interval between each act. Comedy gives way to argument; argument gives way to the family's revealed wound; the final scene at the fountain belongs to nobody who set out to be funny.

PRODUCTION TIMELINE

- **June 2026** Open auditions in Lausanne. Casting for the eight live tracks.
- **Late June – July 2026** Line readings with cast members as availability allows. Initial table work and dramaturgical conversations.
- **August – November 2026** Weekly rehearsals through the autumn, building toward opening. Cast and creative team commit to a single weekly call.
- **Opening** Late autumn 2026. A short run of three or four performances. Dates and venue to be announced.

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